

Poll Aggregation and Pollster Credibility

Methodology white paper for the Polling Desk — how we blend polls, score pollsters, and turn the poll-versus-market gap into trades

1. Abstract

The Polling Desk maintains a FiveThirtyEight-style weighted average of national 2028 Democratic primary polls and sets it against live prediction-market prices. This paper documents every weight in the pipeline, with particular attention to the question the reader asked us to answer precisely: how credibility is assigned to each pollster and each poll. The framework descends directly from the published methodologies of FiveThirtyEight (G. Elliott Morris's 2024 pollster-ratings paper and the polling-average methodology) and Nate Silver's primary-forecasting work. Where we simplify, we say so.

2. Why an average at all

A single poll of 500 people carries a sampling margin of error near ± 4.4 points, and total error is larger because nonsampling error — frame coverage, weighting choices, question wording, differential response — does not appear in the reported margin. Silver's own 2024 retrospective puts average general-election polling bias around 4 points even in aggregate. Averaging across firms cancels idiosyncratic error, and weighting the average by poll quality cancels it faster. 538's internal test found POLLSCORE-weighted averages measurably less biased than recency-and-size weighting alone. Aggregation is not a luxury; it is the minimum standard of care.

3. Credibility of the pollster

538 rates pollsters on two axes. Accuracy: each historical poll's error and bias are measured against the election result, benchmarked against how difficult the race was to poll (Excess Error), compared against other pollsters in the same race (Relative Excess Error), shrunk toward a prior based on transparency-organization membership and partisan clientele (Predictive Error), and penalized for herding — hewing suspiciously close to averages. Transparency: ten yes/no disclosure questions per poll (question wording, crosstabs, weighting variables and targets, sample selection, sponsor disclosure, acknowledgment of nonsampling error), aggregated with time decay and combined with accuracy by Pareto optimality into a 0.5-to-3.0 star rating.

Our desk cannot rerun that full pipeline — it requires 538's 1998-to-present poll database. We instead assign each firm an approximate star rating anchored to 538's published ratings and reasoning, and convert stars to weight as $w = \text{stars} / 3$, floored at 0.3 so that no active pollster is silently zeroed out. The table records every assignment and its justification:

Pollster	Stars	Why
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Emerson College	2.9	Strong track record, transparent methods, member of transparency ecosystem; among the most accurate primary pollsters.
YouGov (incl. Yahoo, BGSU)	2.9	Large panels, disclosed methodology, long accuracy record across cycles.
Echelon Insights	2.8	High transparency, consistent methodology, publishes full crosstabs.
AtlasIntel	2.7	Excellent 2020-2024 accuracy; strong POLLSCORE analogue, though its all-adult samples get a population discount.
JL Partners / Daily Mail	2.0	Competent newer firm; media-sponsored; moderate transparency.
Focaldata, Noble Predictive, Verasight	2.0	Modern online-panel shops with reasonable disclosure but shorter records.
I&I/TIPP	1.8	Long record, mixed accuracy, moderate transparency.
Harvard-Harris, Big Data Poll, Rasmussen, Overton, Lake Research, Yale Youth, Quantus	1.5	Either persistent house lean, partisan clientele, unusual samples, or thin disclosure. Harvard-Harris shows a very large pro-Harris house effect; Lake is a Democratic firm.
Public Sentiment Institute	1.0	Tiny samples, little methodological disclosure.
McLaughlin & Associates, Zogby	0.5	Documented histories of large errors and partisan work; 538's lowest tiers. Included with minimal weight rather than excluded, so exclusion judgment calls cannot steer the average.

Two principles govern the table. First, credibility is earned by disclosure as much as accuracy: a firm that shows its weighting targets and crosstabs can be audited, and 538's research shows such firms have lower error going forward. Second, partisan clientele costs weight — not because partisan pollsters lie, but because firms doing more than ten percent partisan work empirically carry higher error and bias.

4. Credibility of the individual poll

Within a pollster's output, each poll earns weight from four multiplicative terms:

- Recency: weight decays 3 percent per day of age. 538 uses roughly 7 percent per day near election day; two years from the primaries, news moves slowly and a steeper decay would leave the average hostage to whichever firm polled last. A 30-day-old poll retains about 40 percent of full weight.
- Sample size: weight scales with the square root of the sample, capped at 5,000 respondents — 538's cap — because information grows with the root of n, and because one 25,000-person poll should not become the whole average.
- Population: likely-voter samples get full weight, registered voters 0.9, all adults 0.75. This is 538's narrowest-population preference expressed as a continuous weight; primary electorates are small and unrepresentative of adults generally.
- Pollster credibility: the star weight from Section 3.

A poll's final weight is the product. Example: AtlasIntel's May 2026 poll (n = 2,069, all adults, 2.7 stars, ~70 days old) carries weight $0.12 \times 1.86 \times 0.75 \times 0.90 = 0.15$ versus roughly 0.60 for a fresh Echelon likely-voter poll — recency dominating, exactly as intended.

5. House effects

Pollsters have habits. Harvard-Harris shows Kamala Harris 10 to 20 points above the field's average reading; AtlasIntel runs unusually hot on Buttigieg and Ocasio-Cortez. Before averaging, we compute each firm's mean deviation from the unadjusted average, per candidate, across all its polls, and subtract half of it — the same half-correction logic 538 describes for its averages. Half, not all, because a persistent deviation can be house lean or can be genuine methodological insight; correcting fully would assume the crowd is always right, correcting zero would let one loud firm drag the average. Firms with a single poll are left uncorrected — one observation cannot distinguish lean from noise.

6. Validation

The test of a homemade average is agreement with professional aggregators that use richer machinery. As of mid-July 2026: our average has Harris 28.6 percent against RealClearPolling 28.9, 270toWin 29.6, Race to the WH 29.5, VoteHub 28.2. Newsom: ours 16.5, theirs 16.5 to 16.8. Buttigieg: ours ~12.4, theirs 12.2 to 13.0. AOC: ours ~10.3, theirs 9.3 to 11.1. The desk's engine lands inside the professional spread on every major candidate.

7. Polls are not probabilities

A 29 percent poll share two years out is not a 29 percent nomination probability. Early national primary polling chiefly measures name recognition. The historical record of early national leaders roughly two years before the primaries: Lieberman 2004, Clinton 2008, Giuliani 2008 and Jeb Bush 2016 all led and lost; Romney 2012, Clinton 2016, Biden 2020 and Trump 2024 led and won. The early leader converts about half the time — and non-leaders with real paths (Obama 2008 polled ~20 points behind Clinton in 2006) convert far more often than their shares imply. 538's primary models addressed this by adding endorsements and fundamentals to polls; our desk addresses it by refusing to read shares as probabilities at all, and using the market as the probability layer.

8. The edge: polls versus market

The desk's tradeable output is the gap between the weighted poll average and the prediction-market price. Interpreting the July 2026 board:

- Harris — polls 29, market ~8 cents. The market treats her lead as name-ID ghost and pays roughly 11-to-1 against the polling leader. History says early leaders win about half the time; the market says 8 percent. Both cannot be right. This is the boldest available fade of market consensus.
- Ossoff — polls ~2, market ~14 cents. The market prices an announcement polls cannot yet measure, against his own on-record statement that he is not

running. Any Ossoff position, including our wedge, inherits announcement risk the polls will not warn you about.

- Buttigieg — polls ~13, market ~5 cents. The largest gap in the polls' favor among plausible candidates; he leads several likely-voter polls outright. If the polling is signal, this is the value row on the board.
- Newsom — polls ~17, market ~18 cents. Agreement. The control group proving the other gaps are anomalies rather than artifacts of our method.

Strategy rules. One: divergence is information, not automatically a trade — the market has read the same polls, so bet only when you can name what the price is missing. Two: size divergence trades as long shots — quarter-Kelly or less, within the theme cap, using the Ossoff desk's calculator. Three: prefer trades where polls and structure agree against the price (Buttigieg) over trades that require polls to be wrong in a specific direction (Ossoff announcement).

9. Limitations

We do not model herding penalties, do not bootstrap uncertainty intervals, do not impute missing transparency data, and our star assignments are informed approximations of 538's published ratings rather than reproductions. The poll database updates when the desk adds new releases rather than by automated scrape; market prices on the page do refresh live. These are the honest costs of a one-page engine, and none of them move the average outside the professional aggregator spread today.

10. Sources

- G. Elliott Morris, 'How 538's pollster ratings work', ABC News/538, January 2024.
- 538, 'How our polling averages work' (exponential decay, sample-size weighting, house-effect correction).
- FiveThirtyEight, 'Polls policy and FAQs' (poll eligibility, population preference, tracking-poll rules).
- FiveThirtyEight, 'How we're forecasting the primaries' (polls-only versus polls-plus, endorsements and fundamentals).
- Nate Silver, 'So how did the polls do in 2024?', Silver Bulletin (primary polls among the most accurate categories; ~4-point average general-election bias).
- Wikipedia, 'Nationwide opinion polling for the 2028 Democratic Party presidential primaries' (poll database; 270toWin, RealClearPolling, Race to the WH, VoteHub aggregates).
- The Hill and Newsweek reporting, July 2026 (Emerson poll; prediction-market moves; Ossoff's CNN statement that he is not running).